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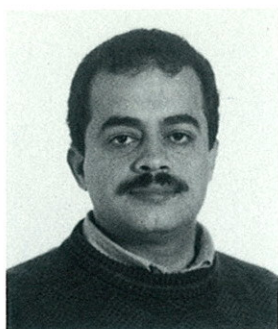
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(Issues in Contemporary Islamic Thought)

Through Muslim Eyes:

M. Rashīd Riḍā and the West

Emad Eldin Shahin



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 بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَنِ الرَّحِيمِ
 وَالصَّلَاةُ وَالسَّلَامُ عَلَى خَاتَمِ الْأَنْبِيَاءِ وَالرُّسُلِ
 وَفَكَرِ رَبِّ زِدْنِي عِلْمًا

*In the Name of Allah,
 the Compassionate, the Merciful,
 Praise be to Allah, Lord of the Universe,
 and Peace and Prayers be upon
 His Final Prophet and Messenger.*

*"... and say: My Lord!
 Cause Me to Grow in Knowledge."*

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَنِ الرَّحِيمِ

اقْرَأْ بِاسْمِ رَبِّكَ الَّذِي خَلَقَ ﴿١﴾ خَلَقَ الْإِنْسَانَ مِنْ عَلَقٍ ﴿٢﴾
اقْرَأْ وَرَبُّكَ الْأَكْرَمُ ﴿٣﴾ الَّذِي عَلَّمَ بِالْقَلَمِ ﴿٤﴾ عَلَّمَ الْإِنْسَانَ
مَا لَمْ يَعْلَمْ ﴿٥﴾

(العلق: ١ - ٥)

Read in the name of your Sustainer, Who has Created man out of a germ cell. Read—for your Sustainer is the Most bountiful One. Who has taught (man) the use of the pen. Taught Man what he did not know.
(Qur'an 96:1-5)

وَاللَّهُ أَخْرَجَكُم مِّن بُطُونِ أُمَّهَاتِكُمْ لَا تَعْلَمُونَ شَيْئًا
وَجَعَلَ لَكُمُ السَّمْعَ وَالْأَبْصَارَ وَالْأَفْئِدَةَ
لَعَلَّكُمْ تَشْكُرُونَ ﴿٧٨﴾

(النحل: ٧٨)

And Allah has brought you forth from your mother's womb knowing nothing—but He has endowed you with hearing, and sight, and minds, so that you might have cause to be grateful.
(Qur'an 16:78)

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Emad Eldin Shahin

International Institute of Islamic Thought
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PREFACE*

Muḥammad Rashīd Riḍā was a prominent member of the reformist school of thought known as al Jāmi'ah al Islāmīyah, a school which had a profound effect on many of the issues confronting the Muslim mind nearly a century ago. If Jamāl al Dīn al Afghānī can be called the founder of this school, and Muḥammad 'Abduh its mentor, then Rashīd Riḍā may be called its articulator and third most important personality.

In attempting to describe this school of thought, it may be best to say that it was based on the idea of rapproachment or, more specifically, of bringing Islamic and Western thought closer together. This was to be done by minimizing or downplaying their differences. In this way, it was hoped that the Muslims would learn to be at ease with Western thought and to accept it as comprehensive and universal in nature, or at least as the logical outgrowth of ideas originating with Ibn Khaldūn, Ibn Rushd, or al Ghazzālī.

Many who subscribed to this school of thought were involved in the attempt to derive points of agreement from the two intellectual traditions. For the most part, however, these attempts were overly simplistic and insufficient to make the process of rapproachment an interactive one, or even one that could be appreciated by both sides. As it turned out, the loser in almost every case was Islamic thought, as many of the school's members believed its value was to lend legitimacy to the claims of universality made by Western thought. The objective of quite a few of the Jāmi'ah Islāmīyah thinkers was to prepare the Muslim mind to accept Western and, in particular, secular thought. Certain thinkers went so far as to interpret Islamic concepts and doctrines in a way that would make them acceptable to modern secularism.

It is not the intention of the author to undervalue this school of thought or the positive role it played in regard to several issues of importance. What he seeks to do is to explain that Riḍā

* This preface was prepared in Arabic by Dr. Tāhā Jābir al 'Alwānī and translated into English by Y. T. DeLorenzo, IIIT Research.

differed from the other adherents of this school of thought in that the ideas of rapprochement espoused by the others became for him ideas of reformation, including the attempt to revive the institution of *ijtihād* and his emphasis on the importance of culture in restructuring the Ummah. Thus he wrote an exhaustive commentary on the Qur'an, drawing heavily from the writings and teachings of 'Abduh. Likewise *al Manār*, the journal he edited for over thirty years, served as a forum from which he circulated those ideas he considered most important for Muslims to be acquainted with. Nonetheless, Riḍā's reformist thought never went much further than reconciliation, though it might be said to have been a step on the path to revival.

During his lifetime, Riḍā witnessed many significant political events in the region, including the collapse of the Ottoman caliphate and the subsequent rise of nation states from its rubble. In his political life, Riḍā established a number of secret and public political organizations, as he maintained relationships with political figures and parties both at home and abroad. In every case, however, his dealings grew out of an increasing trepidation of western colonial ambitions. Thus his fascination with some aspects of Western thought may be seen as an attempt to use, for the purpose of establishing a modern Arab and Islamic state, the same means used by the West in establishing itself as the dominant world power.

The theme of many of Riḍā's writings was to discover and analyze the reasons for the West's progress and to invite Muslims to adopt the same strategies for their own betterment. As the depredations of the West against the Muslims increased, however, he began to have doubts regarding his earlier admiration of Western thought and progress. It was a bitter experience for him and those who shared his views to see that the West's culture and civilization did not have the power to prevent it from committing the worst crimes against Muslims and Muslim countries.

In publishing this book, the first in a series of graduate dissertations,¹ the International Institute of Islamic Thought hopes to explain that the encounter with the West still poses serious challenges to the Muslims. Such challenges are dictated by the absence of a framework to guide the process of interaction between the Islamic and Western cultures. It also hopes to focus on Riḍās attempts to deal with the disorienting effects of the encroachment of alien values and institutions on the structure of Muslim society and to outline a framework that would enable Muslims to improve their conditions and assume their assigned role while preserving their indigenous values and national identity.

In closing, we thank Dr. Emad Eldin Shahin for his efforts in writing a book that may be taken as an example of how the past may be linked to the present. May this be another successful step on the long path of enlightening the Ummah, and may Dr. Shahin's example inspire others to make their own contributions towards this noble goal.

Ṭāhā Jābir al 'Alwānī
The International Institute of Islamic Thought
Rabi' al Ākhir 1414 / September 1993
Herndon, Virginia USA

¹ This book was originally presented to the American University at Cairo as a Master's dissertation in Political Science.

INTRODUCTION

In the nineteenth century, Arab and Muslim societies were forcefully drawn into direct contact with the vibrant civilization of the West with its advanced sciences and technological achievements, its political and economic institutions, its social and cultural values, and its philosophical and intellectual trends. These factors were the outcome of the long experimentation, conflict, and development which the West had undergone before it became an imperial power. When the West penetrated the Muslim world, profound and rapid changes occurred in almost every sphere of life. Since then, the Muslim world has been in a state of "transition" or "transformation." However, it has not had enough time to gradually absorb the new elements and work out a sound synthesis between the old and the new.

The introduction of foreign systems of education, administration, and legislation, as well as economic and political patterns, shook the bases of Muslim society. These changes did not produce the same results as they had in the West for several reasons. First of all, they were imposed from above and not through the interaction of the internal dynamics of Muslim society. Second, they were introduced by foreign forces and powers to whom resistance was the national duty of Arabs and Muslims. Third, they clashed with the dominant complex conditions of Muslim societies. They created structural imbalances as the gap between the indigenous Islamic belief system and the alien non-Islamic values began to widen.¹ Consequently, the Arab began to realize that he "lives in a world that he feels is not his own, that he can only partially understand, and certainly cannot control."²

¹Nadav Safran, *Egypt in Search of Political Community: 1804-1952* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1961), 245.

²Wilfred Cantwell Smith, *Islam in Modern History* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1957), 97.

From the late nineteenth century until 1924, the Ottoman state gradually disintegrated, and for the first time Muslims were directly controlled by non-Muslims. With disintegration came dualism. The most flagrant example was education. Two systems of education, traditional and modern or Western, existed side by side. The members of the second type, known as "the Westernized" by the traditionally educated, climbed the social ladder and gained dominance over the state apparatus. They found their place quite easily in the modern administration and the new economic and political institutions.

The encounter with the West, whose might was its most apparent feature, influenced Arab and Muslim intellectuals. They were strongly impressed by its material and military achievements. This encounter led them to compare their stagnant condition with that of the more dynamic West. Questions arose: What were the secrets behind the West's ascendance and the reasons for the East's decline? How could the East be revived? How could it emulate the West without losing its identity? Could it reconcile the prevailing values of the East and the West?³

Three major intellectual trends soon emerged. The first was Islamic orthodoxy (i.e., Wahhābiyah, Maḥdiyyah, and Sanūsiyah) that rejected the West, took refuge in the past, and protected itself behind tradition. The second was a liberal secular trend that rejected the traditional social heritage and stressed the liberal and secular aspects of modern Western civilization as models to follow. The third was Islamic revivalism or reform, led by Jamāl al Dīn al Afghānī, Muḥammad 'Abduh, and Muḥammad Rashīd Riḍā, which sought to reconcile the two cultures.

It is this last trend which is the basis of this book. Thus, this book focuses on the encounter between the West and the East and how this cultural challenge was perceived by Muḥammad Rashīd Riḍā, a leading Arab intellectual and Muslim reformer.⁴

³Adīb Nassūr, "Muqaddimah li Dirāsāt al Fikr al 'Arabī al Siyāsī," in *Al Fikr al 'Arabī fī Mi'at 'Ām: 1850-1945* (Beirut: AUB Press, 1966), 84-5.

⁴Excerpts from this book appeared earlier in Emad Eldin Shahin, "Muḥammad Rashīd Riḍā's Perspectives on the West," *The Muslim World* 79, no. 2 (April 1989).

Chapter One

INTELLECTUAL FORMATION

There are several reasons behind the choice of Rashīd Ridā (1865-1935) as the focus for this study. First of all, Ridā was a member of the Islamic reform trend. This trend, based on the teachings and efforts of al Afghānī and 'Abduh, played a major role during the early years of the encounter with the West and is still highly significant and impressive in Muslim countries. Ridā, throughout the years of his active participation, made great contributions to the preservation and the dissemination of this trend of thought.¹ He is also a connecting link between its early generation (al Afghānī and 'Abduh) and the succeeding generation that appeared in the 1930s. As 'Abduh was the stylist of al Afghānī's thoughts in the Paris-based journal *al 'Urwah al Wuthqā* (The Indissoluble Bond), Ridā was the interpreter and defender of 'Abduh's thoughts in his Cairo-based journal *al Manār* (The Lighthouse). It was due to Ridā that "the ideology of reformism reached wider circles throughout the world and kept alive the original impulse of al Afghānī and 'Abduh."² During his visit to Tunisia and Algeria in 1903, 'Abduh noted the influence of Ridā and *al Manār* among the North Africans.³

Ridā's efforts extended beyond the mere propagation of 'Abduh's and al Afghānī's ideas, for he managed to develop his own line of thinking.

Ridā devoted most of his career to propagating a revivalist interpretation of Islamic faith and institutions.... He wrote much more voluminously than his master. He elaborated a doctrine of Islamic law and politics much

¹Albert Hourani, *Arabic Thought in the Liberal Age: 1798-1939* (London: Oxford University Press, 1970), 224, 226.

²Hisham Sharabi, *Arab Intellectuals and the West, The Formative Years: 1875-1914* (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1970), 51-5.

³Muhammad Rashīd Ridā, *Tārīkh al Ustādh al Imām al Shaykh Muḥammad 'Abduh* (Cairo: Maṭba'at al Manār, 1931), 1, 872.

more systematic and specific than anything 'Abduh had attempted.⁴

Furthermore, Ridā's ideas and style shaped religion with a national feature which later affected the political environment in Egypt. The efforts of "Ridā and al Kawākibī laid the grounds of the Arab national movements."⁵

In 1902, Ridā published 'Abd al Rahmān al Kawākibī's book *Umm al Qurā* (Mother of the Villages) in his journal. He also wrote articles advocating Arab independence, among them "The Arabs and Turks" and "The Arab Question." His thought influenced the younger generation of intellectuals in Egypt,⁶ marking in particular the growth and spread from 1927 of religious and political groups. The most important of these were the Muslim Youth Association and the Muslim Brothers, which played an increasingly political role among the urban middle and lower classes.⁷

The second reason for choosing Ridā is that he and his journal *al Manār* witnessed the events of 1898 to 1935, a time of drastic and profound change in the Muslim world. After 'Abduh's death in 1905, Ridā was one of the very few Egyptians who actively called for Islamic reform, defended its ideology, and articulated its views. His thought was formed during the period of the most vigorous Western imperialism in Arab and Muslim history, a period that saw continued Western expansion in the area, the collapse of the Ottoman Empire, the emergence of new Arab political entities under Western tutelage, and the crystallization of specific political, constitutional, and cultural patterns. This period also witnessed the growth of Western institutions, economic control, and changes in the education system, one parallel with the emergence of regional, ethnic, and sectarian communities, and the establishment of secular political parties.

⁴Malcolm Kerr, *Islamic Reform: The Political and Legal Theories of Muhammad 'Abduh and Rashīd Ridā* (Los Angeles: University of California Press, 1966), 153.

⁵Peter Mansfield, *The Arabs* (London: Penguin Books, Ltd., 1976), 169.

⁶Marcelle Colombe, *Taṭawwur Miṣr*, trans. Zuhair al Shāyib (Cairo: Maktabat Sa'id Ra'fat, 1972), 167, 174.

⁷Ibid., 174-5.

Ridā's contribution during this period was not limited to intellectual stimulation, for he also played an active political role. He was involved in the establishment of both secret and public political organizations which struggled for greater Arab participation in the Ottoman administration. He advocated a constitution and attempted to prepare the Arabs for self-rule and independence. He organized the *Jam'iyat al Shūrā al 'Uthmānīyah* (Society of Ottoman Consultation) in 1905 and, together with Shiblī Shumayyāl and Iskandar Ammūn, founded the Decentralization party in 1912. During the First World War, he was contacted by the British, who wanted him to spread the idea of independence among the Arabs. Ridā had good relations with both Sharīf Husayn of Makkah and with 'Abd al 'Azīz ibn Sa'ūd, the latter of whom Ridā believed would be able to create a new Arab state which would form the nucleus of an Islamic caliphate. Moreover, Ridā was active in the Syrian political struggle during the First World War and served as the president of the Syrian Congress in 1920. In this capacity, he negotiated for Syria's independence with the British and the French. He was also a member of the Syrian delegation to Geneva and served on the political committee in Cairo during the Syrian revolt of 1925-26.⁸

Intellectually, Ridā was a major defender of his society's values and an active opponent of Western encroachment and the westernizers who advocated the wholesale adoption of Western values. He was "passionately concerned with finding the reasons for the weakness and backwardness of the Muslim world in relation to the West"⁹ and, more than anyone else, clearly perceived the challenges and forces which led to the disintegration of Islam. Specifically, "Ridā was one of the few Muslim thinkers in Egypt who saw early and clearly the threat posed by the concept of nationalism on Islamic doctrine."¹⁰ He realized that Islam could not be revitalized through the narrow conservatism of the traditional ulama or through the blind imitation of Westernizers. He criticized the former for their ignorance and submission to the rulers, and the latter for their unreasonable attempts to

⁸Hourani, *Arabic Thought*, 227.

⁹Mansfield, *The Arabs*, 168.

¹⁰Safran, *Egypt*, 82.

substitute the indigenous characteristics of their society with those of another culture.¹¹ In 1922, Riḍā participated in the formation of the *Jam'iyat al Rābiṭah al Sharqīyah*, which had social and scientific objectives and sought progress through the development of education and science. It also worked for strengthening the bonds between Muslim peoples, reviving Islamic civilization, and drawing on those Western virtues that did not contradict Islamic values.¹²

Early Years

Rashīd Riḍā's personal character and intellectual orientation were formed by a variety of factors. He was born in a village near Tripoli, Lebanon, in 1865. Lebanon, at this time, was part of the Ottoman Empire and suffered from the repressive policies directed by Istanbul towards all who called for reform.

Riḍā's family claimed descent from the Prophet Muḥammad. This status meant that all male family members could claim the honorary title of *al Sayyid*, which gave them an elevated social position. It also allowed them to exercise influence in religious, judicial, social, and, sometimes, political matters and was a major determinant of the education which the young Riḍā would receive. In his case, he was sent to the village school to learn the Qur'an and acquire a basic education.¹³

Riḍā's early years witnessed the emergence of a new type of education, one based on the Western model and spread by European missionaries, the Ottoman government, individuals, and ethnic communities. Riḍā spent one year in a government school.¹⁴ When "an enlightened and moderately progressive"¹⁵

¹¹*Al Manār*, 7 (1904): 51-2.

¹²*Ibid.*, 23 (1921-22): 223.

¹³Wajīh Kawtharānī, *Mukhtārāt Siyāsīyah min Majallat al Manār* (Beirut: Dār al Ṭalī'ah, 1980), 5-6.

¹⁴Muḥammad Rashīd Riḍā, *Al Manār wa al Azhar* (Cairo: Maṭba'at al Manār, 1934), 140.

¹⁵Kerr, *Islamic Reform*, 154.

scholar, Shaykh Ḥusayn al Jisr, opened an Islamic national school in Tripoli, Ridā joined it as well.

Al Jisr believed that Muslims could progress by synthesizing traditional Islamic religious education and Europe's modern natural sciences and thus develop an Islamic system of education to rival the Western methods of teaching.¹⁶ In this school, Ridā studied logic, mathematics, natural sciences, Turkish, French, Arabic and the religious sciences. As Ridā proved his high scholarly ability, his master introduced him to the world of journalism in Tripoli, where he wrote in several journals and acquired some fame.¹⁷ Ridā also frequented the missions and the liberal Christian intellectual communities and became acquainted with their discussions, books, and journals,¹⁸ including *al Muq-tataf* and *al Tabīb*. These two journals had a profound impact on him, for they introduced him to modern knowledge and the new world of the West. In 1892, he obtained the degree of "scholar."

Al Ghazālī's *Iḥyā'* had a profound and permanent impact on Ridā. Feeling the need to reform the declining conditions of the Muslims and the degenerating Sufi practices of the masses, he wrote *al Hikmah al Shar'iyah* (The Legal Wisdom), which criticized such practices. As he could not publish in Lebanon, he published it later in Egypt.

At this time, a broad-based reform movement inspired by the decadence of the Muslims and the challenges posed by the West was under way in Egypt. It sought to revive the Muslims by sweeping aside all of the degenerate practices that had brought about their decline. Al Afghānī was the first to agitate against indigenous despotism and Western imperialism while pointing out the differences between Islam and the West. According to Laroui, al Afghānī is important because he was the first reformer to consider the East and the West as two opposing historical entities. In Egypt, 'Abduh learnt from al Afghānī how

¹⁶Aḥmad al Sharbāṣī, *Muḥammad Rashīd Ridā: 'Aṣruhu, Ḥayātuhu wa Ma-ṣādir Thaqāfatihī* (Cairo: al Majlis al 'Alā li al Shu'ūn al Islāmīyah, 1970), 1, 121.

¹⁷Ibrāhīm al 'Adawī, *Muḥammad Rashīd Ridā: al Imām al Muṭtahid* (Cairo: al Hay'ah al Miṣriyah al 'Āmmah li al Ta'līf wa al Nashr, 1964), 30.

¹⁸Ridā, *Al Manār wa al Azhar*, 193.

to perceive issues concerning the future of the Muslims. In Istanbul, Luṭfī al Sayyid acquired from him the meaning of constitution and democracy, and Salāmah Mūsà learnt his favorite phrase "industry, science, and progress."¹⁹ Smith had the same opinion about al Afghānī:

[he] . . . seemed to have been the first Muslim revivalist to use the concepts 'Islam' and the 'West' as connoting correlative and of course antagonizing historical phenomena.²⁰

In 1884, al Afghānī and 'Abduh founded *al 'Urwah al Wuthqā* in Paris and used it to introduce to the Arabs such new ideas as freedom, independence, unity, and the rights of the ruled. This publication had four main themes: reform of the state, agitation against despotism and repression, the struggle against imperialism, and Muslim solidarity and unity. It explained the reasons for the Muslim world's decline: ignorance, fatalism, disunity, and despotic and incapable rulers. In addition, it sought to understand why the West had achieved such a level of development. According to al Afghānī, the West had progressed because it had mastered science, technology, organization, and diplomacy.²¹ If Muslims were to redeem themselves, they had to acquire these commendable values and develop them as much as possible. *Al 'Urwah* claimed that the Muslims had been betrayed by their rulers. These leaders, obsessed by greed and ignorance, had handed—and continued to hand—their countries over to foreigners who exploited their decline so as to destroy their solidarity.²²

Al Afghānī's solution was not the wholesale adoption of Western institutions and values, but rather the purification of Islam from degenerate practices. He called upon Muslims to rise against tyrannical rulers and unite under the banner of pan-Islamism, essentially a nationalist manifestation, against the

¹⁹Abdallah Laroui, *Al 'Idiyūlūjīyah al 'Arabīyah al Mu 'āshirah* (Beirut: Dār al Haqīqah, 1981), 40.

²⁰Smith, *Islam*, 49.

²¹Safran, *Egypt*, 44.

²²'Afāf Luṭfī al Sayyid, *Egypt and Cromer: A Study in Anglo-Egyptian Relations* (New York: Frederick A. Praeger, 1969), 88.

menacing threat of the West and foreign occupation. One result of its agitation against foreign occupation and despotic rulers was the banning of *al 'Urwah* in Egypt and India and its confiscation in the Ottoman Empire. After publishing eighteen issues in one year, it was discontinued. Thereafter, al Afghānī and 'Abduh went in two different directions. The first eventually ended up in Istanbul, where he spent the rest of his life, while 'Abduh went to Beirut, where he resided for five years. In Beirut, he seemed to tire of al Afghānī's revolutionary program and began to work for moderate goals like advocating religious and educational reforms.

Al 'Urwah had a considerable impact upon its readers, many of whom were students, intellectuals, and scholars. One of these readers was Ridā, who heard about the movement and thoughts of al Afghānī and 'Abduh from the followers of the exiled Ahmad 'Urābī, who resided in Ridā's house in Lebanon, and from reading *al 'Urwah*. This journal had a tremendous influence on him, for it completely altered his perceptions and introduced him to a new stage in his intellectual life. Ridā wrote:

All I wanted to do before I had read *al 'Urwah al Wuthqā* was to teach the tenets of Islam and the transitory nature of life on earth. Now I saw a new light: to work for the unification of the Muslims of the world. My duty I now knew lay in guiding the faithful to the ways of progress and modern civilization.²³

As Ridā's idea of reform had been broadened and the Ottoman Empire's repressive policies in Lebanon hindered his aims, Ridā contacted al Afghānī to see if he could become his student in Istanbul. However, al Afghānī died before this goal could be realized. Ridā therefore went to Egypt, for the British occupiers of Egypt were relatively more tolerant of personal expression, and because several intellectuals known to him had already fled there. Another factor in this decision was his desire to start his own journal, which would become known as *al Manār* (The Lighthouse). He had been offered the editorship of a well-

²³As quoted in Jamal Ahmad, *The Intellectual Origins of Egyptian Nationalism* (London: Oxford University Press, 1960), 29.



ABOUT THIS BOOK

When Western influences began to pervade the Muslim world over a century ago, intense and rapid changes occurred in almost every sphere of Muslim life. The encounter with the West profoundly influenced Arab and Muslim intellectuals and led them to compare their stagnant condition with that of the more dynamic West. Questions arose: What were the secrets behind the West's ascendancy and the reasons for the East's decline? How could the East be revived? How could it emulate the West without losing its identity? Could it reconcile the prevailing values in the East with those of the West?

In spite of its brevity, this book offers the reader a fascinating study of how one of the century's most important Muslim thinkers dealt with the ideas and institutions of the West. While Riḍā's intellectual odyssey ran from guarded admiration of the West to contempt for its hypocrisy and even to calls for open rebellion, what is important to note is that his foremost concern was with values and ideas, in the tradition of the hadith which states that wisdom is like the believer's lost camel, it is his to mount regardless of where he may find it. Thus, while Riḍā could hardly have endorsed the colonial policies of a Bismarck, for example, he nonetheless admired the man's thinking in regard to education.

Through the efforts of Muḥammad Rashīd Riḍā an entire generation of Muslim intellectuals was brought face to face with the thought of several of the West's most important writers and social philosophers. Finally, though the inhumanity of the battlefield may have convinced Riḍā that Western politics were about the cynical exercise of power, the humanity of the West's thinkers remained the standard by which he judged the West in general.

